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**NEW WAVE** Iqra Hasan campaigning in Kairana; (below) Azad at a public meeting in Nagina

**contest, they are even arranging food for us," he says.**

**Meanwhile, in Kairana, 28-year-old Iqra Hasan is consolidating support in the Hasan family stronghold. A third-generation politician, she is taking on sitting BJP MP and Jat leader Pradeep Chaudhary. UK-returned Iqra, a post-graduate in law, is on a mission to debunk the narrative that the vote is polarised in her constituency. "Kairana is near Delhi-NCR, but we still do not have factories or a medical college here. I want all this and more for my people," she says. The BSP has fielded a Thakur, Shripal Rana, here, which could make things tight for the BJP. Muslims make up over 40 per cent of voters in the seat.**

**The poll scene is equally hectic in Bijnor, where the NDA candidate is Chandan Chauhan, 35, of the RLD. The Meerapur MLA is the son of ex-MP Sanjay Singh Chauhan, a redoubtable Gujjar leader in these parts. Chauhan also faces a triangular contest as the BSP has fielded local Jat leader Chaudhary Vijendra Singh, while the INDIA candidate is the SP's Deepak Saini, an OBC leader. Bijnor has over 35 per cent Muslim voters who could play a key role in the result. Chauhan is hoping that the Muslim vote gets split between the SP and BSP and claims that a section might even vote for him as his family has old connections with many Muslim families here.**

what narrative the Opposition weaves, it is going to be a one-sided outcome in the BJP's favour," he says.

## The Triangular Contests

In Kairana, the SP has fielded the London-returned Iqra Hasan, daughter of the late ex-MP Munawwar Hasan, against sitting BJP MP Pradeep Chaudhary. In tune with her Master's from the School of Oriental and African Studies, Iqra has an urbane approach, focusing on higher education and industry. Akhilesh hopes her appeal transcends the confines of community, and signs are he may be right. Moreover, the BSP has fielded ex-serviceman Sripal Rana, a Thakur candidate who could blunt any saffron edge. The Thakurs, a traditional BJP vote base, are upset that barring Sarvesh Kumar Singh in Moradabad, the party has not given adequate representation to their brethren this time in western UP. Similarly, the Tyagis are upset that they haven't got any tickets.

'Rajput *samman* (pride)', in fact, has been hurting for a while now. They accuse the BJP of "sidelining the Rajputs". On April 7, members of the community held a massive mahapanchayat in the Nanauta area of Saharanpur. The party's decision to replace Gen. V.K. Singh (retd) with Atul Kumar Garg in Ghaziabad triggered outrage and several local Thakur biggies were heard airing the complaint that "10 per cent" of western UP had got just "one ticket". The Tyagi and Saini communities have also been holding panchayats in many places. Former BJP member Shrikant Tyagi, who has had a few run-ins with the law and now heads a community outfit, has announced that his supporters will vote for the candidate strong enough to defeat the BJP. Party sources say CM Yogi and Union defence minister Rajnath Singh (both Thakurs) have been deployed to manage the crisis.

## Switch and Slide

One of the keenest contests is unfolding in Muzaffarnagar where two-time MP Sanjeev Balyan of the BJP is in the race again. The BSP has fielded OBC leader Dara Singh Prajapati whose caste cohorts could again dent Balyan's chances. This is also old home turf for the RLD, but a section of Jats feels let down by Jayant's last-minute decision to go with the NDA, given his exertions in the past five years to get Hindus and Muslims back together with '*bhaichara* (friendship)' meetings. Many Jats may still vote for the BJP. "The RLD's alliance with the BJP is politically incorrect, but now we need to protect the honour of Chaudhary *sahab*'s (the late ex-PM Charan Singh, Jayant's grandfather) family," says Chaudhry Ram Veer, a retired teacher from Sardhana here. In 2019, Balyan had defeated then RLD chief Ajit Singh (Jayant's father) by a margin of just 6,526 votes. Now, Jayant is campaigning for him as an ally.

The SP candidate in Muzaffarnagar is Jat leader Harendra Malik, who is trying to make the most of RLD's "perfidy", saying the BJP was only using the latter for its own ends. His son Pankaj Malik, MLA from Charthawal, says, "A wrong perception has been created that all Jats are with the BJP now. My father is the biggest Jat leader here. He lives 24x7 in Muzaffarnagar and raises every local issue strongly. We are sure a major chunk of our community will vote for us."

Prof. Sudhir Panwar of Lucknow University, who's an SP acolyte and western UP native, says, "The BJP wants to make Muslims and Jats irrelevant, that's why they took the RLD in. Both these communities are very influential here.... They have managed to hook the RLD, but it'll not help them." RLD national secretary Anupam Mishra thinks otherwise, saying the alliance will sweep the region. There's surely a split, but how wide open? ■